



metroPLUS

THE HINDU



Take a boat ride at Pulicat to spot pink flamingoes with fishermen and birders **P2**

JYOTIKA EXPLORES THE HINDI OTT SPACE **P4**



Police Museum, Egmore

Most visitors do not know this place exists. The Tamil Nadu Police Museum in Egmore covers two centuries of law enforcement in Madras and later Tamil Nadu – colonial-era handcuffs, antique firearms, communication equipment, dioramas of notable crime scenes, and displays on landmark cases tried in the state. This Indo-Saracenic building is housed in what was the city’s Police Commissionerate from 1856 to 2014, before it moved to its present location opposite the Kirk. “A wall panel discusses the gory Auto Shankar case; alongside it is a sub-jail where visitors can enter and look at life from behind bars,” states an article from *The Hindu*. There is a section on officers killed in the line of duty that is handled with some restraint. There is also a ‘Seemai Vandī’, an old patrol cycle for police personnel in the 1800s. The exhibits are uneven – some cases are dense with detail, others thin – but the overall arc, from Madras Presidency constabulary to modern police, is coherent and more interesting than you would expect. The once-white structure and its grounds became the headquarters of the first Police Commissioner of Madras, Lieutenant-Colonel John Carne Boulderson in 1856.

The Police Museum is open from 11am to 7pm everyday except Tuesday. Entry is ₹10 and an additional ₹20 is charged to enter the fake jail.

STEPOUT



Brass and bourbon

The Residency Towers Chennai’s newest space, Triniti, leans fully into the language of a classic jazz lounge. The two-floor venue brings together live performances, a dedicated cigar lounge, and a menu that draws from both global influences and Chennai’s own flavours. The cocktails are inspired by areas in Chennai like George Town and the Coromandel coast. *Triniti is now open. A meal for two costs ₹2,000 without alcohol. For reservations, call 9344912033.*



Rail Museum, Villivakkam

The Rail Museum in Chennai is amusing. The open-air museum is near the Integral Coach Factory’s furnishing division with heritage locomotives parked on tracks you can walk between. The collection includes narrow-gauge hill railway engines, a royal saloon car once used by a Nizami prince, and working models of diesel and electric engines. There is a miniature train ride that children take very seriously. The outdoor setting works in its favour because you get a sense of scale. There is also an indoor space with miniature models of trains. Worth noting: the interpretive signage is patchy and some engines are in better condition than others. Come in the morning before it gets hot and give yourself anywhere between 60 and 90 minutes. The locomotives do not need much explanation. They are large enough to speak for themselves.

The Rail Museum is open from 10am to 5pm everyday except on Monday. Entry is priced at ₹40.

From a colonial fortress to a highway of vintage Cadillacs, the city’s museums hold stories that no textbook has ever told quite right. With World Museum Day just behind us on May 18, here’s a refresher on the exhibits and spaces across Chennai that are worth rediscovering

Exhibit A, Chennai



Fort St George Museum

If you really think about it, the fort in itself is the exhibit. Completed in 1644, the first English fortress in India still functions as the Tamil Nadu Secretariat, which means soldiers at the gate might have once given off the same bureaucratic energy some 300 years ago. The museum inside is small but good: Raj-era coins, regimental portraits, Persian manuscripts, and the original land deed of Chennapatna signed over to the East India Company. St Mary’s Church located next door, consecrated in 1680, is the oldest Anglican church East of the Suez and worth the walk. There is also military commander and former

British Prime Minister Sir Arthur Wellesley’s Madras residence on the premises, and a number of gates: St George’s Gate, Wallajah Gate, and the Sea Gates (once the passage way for boats to enter the fort premises. People would once fish in the moats). Do not miss Lord Cornwallis’ cupola, his statue with an insensitive frieze around the base of Tipu Sultan’s sons being handed over as hostages till reparation was paid. There are several cannons on the premises. Do not expect a polished visitor experience – the labels are sparse and the lighting is old. But for anyone trying to understand how this city started, there is no better place to stand.

Fort St George is open from 9am to 5pm everyday except on Friday. Entry is ₹15 for an Indian and ₹100 for foreigners.

Sanjana Ganesh
sanjana.g@thehindu.co.in

AVM Heritage Museum

Inside the AVM Studios compound in Vadapalani, there is a private collection of vintage cars including Cadillacs, Rolls-Royces, Studebakers, and pre-war European models, among many, assembled over decades by the AVM family, whose film studio has been running since 1945. Several cars have direct connections to Tamil film history and the caretakers know the stories. They might tell you if you ask politely. An article in *The Hindu* talks about a suave 1945 Buick car used in multiple hit Tamil films, including *Sakalakala Vallavan*, *Manidhan* and *Nallavanuku Nallavan* on display. Access is not fully public yet and it helps to call ahead. However, this is not not unusual for private collections of this kind. The cars are maintained, not mothballed. If you have any interest in either automotive history or Tamil cinema, this is worth the arrangement. It does not try to be a museum in the institutional sense. It is more like someone’s very well-curated garage.

AVM Heritage Museum is open between Friday and Sunday from 10am to 5pm. Entry fee is priced at ₹200. Contact 8939890506 for tickets.



DakshinaChitra Museum

About 25 kilometres down the ECR is DakshinaChitra, an open-air heritage complex of traditional homes and craft workshops transplanted from across Kerala, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, and Tamil Nadu. The buildings – a Chettinad mansion, a Kerala courtyard house, an Andhra craftsman’s workshop – are reconstructed from original materials. Artisans work on site: weaving, pottery, woodwork. The institution also regularly curates exhibits and shows for people to watch, and get a deep, grounded understanding of South Indian culture. Founded in 1996, it is one of the more rigorously maintained cultural institutions in the South. Take a morning, rather than an afternoon off. The light is better and it is cooler. The ECR drive alone makes the trip worthwhile.

DakshinaChitra Museum is open from 10am to 6pm everyday except Tuesday. Entry is priced at ₹350.



How to notice Nature

Visual arts educator Amala Aiana is offering two art workshops for young learners. My Art Journal (May 25–29, 10.30am to 12pm) is a guided workshop for children aged five to 10, introducing participants to drawing, colour theory, and creative journaling through reflective and imaginative exercises. Noticing Nature (May 25–29, 3pm to 4.30pm) is designed for children aged five to 10 years, encouraging them to closely observe the natural world through drawing and mixed media explorations inspired by flora, fauna, and the elements. @Forum Art Gallery, Adyar. Fee per workshop is ₹6,500. To register, call 8778726960.



Gather for the insect choir

Soumik Datta’s *Melodies in Slow Motion*, which premiered in Mumbai last month, comes to Chennai for four immersive performances exploring the fragility of the natural world through sound. Joined by Sumesh Narayanan (mridangam), Sayee Rakshith (violin), and Debjit Patitundi (tabla), Datta blends live music with field recordings of intertidal zones and insect choirs captured by sound designer Rahul Nandkarni. Audiences will experience the performance through individual headphones, alongside spatially mixed audio and projected visuals. *Twice daily on May 21 and 22 (4pm and 7pm) at Offbeat Music Ventures, RA Puram. Tickets at kynhood.com.*



Sacred stories

Temples hold more than history. Their walls tell us tales from centuries ago. Marundeeswarar Temple: Stories & Reflections, a workshop, explores the *sthalapuranam* (legends) of the Marundeeswarar Temple in Thiruvannmiyur while tracing their connections to personal reflection, symbolism, art, and lived tradition. The session will be led by R Parthasarathy, a Chennai-based tech architect, yoga therapist, and explorer of Indic arts, yoga, and temple traditions. @Backyard, Adyar. May 24, 4pm onwards. Fee is ₹500. To register, call 9840601550.

Government Museum, Egmore

Founded in 1851, this is the second oldest museum in India, spread across six buildings on a garden campus in Egmore. The collection is genuinely wide: Bronze Age archaeology, natural history with taxidermied animals and fossil casts, a numismatics gallery, and – the main draw – one of the finest collections of Chola bronzes in the world. The Nataraja figures here are the real thing, not reproductions, and they are displayed without the reverence-performativity of bigger institutions. The campus has an agreeably rambling quality; it was not designed as a unit and it shows. Budget



at least three hours, more if the bronzes slow you down, which they will. The museum also houses the largest collection of antique Roman coins outside of Rome, quite the indicator of Tamil Nadu’s erstwhile trading prowess. A bonus feature of visiting the Government Museum is the ability to walk into the newly-revamped Connemara Public Library, an institution and the iconic National Art Gallery. Do not miss the ornate cannon seized from Tipu Sultan’s army or the others relocated from the Danes of Tranquebar.

Government Museum is open from 9.30am to 5pm except on Fridays. Entry for Indians is priced at ₹15 and ₹250 for foreigners. There is a separate charge to use cameras.

Akila Kannadasan
akila.k@thehindu.co.in

Fisherman M Yuvaraj bustles about his fibreboat, filling fuel in the engine, and checking if everything is in order. He even throws in an umbrella in case it rains. It is almost 4pm when he pushes his boat close to the bank of Pulicat lake. The 57-year-old is not setting out on a fishing trip. He is taking a group of us to see flamingoes.

Pulicat is the second largest brackish waterbody in India, next to Chilika in Odisha. The lagoon that straddles Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh is home to a protected bird sanctuary with birders visiting through the year. While Yuvaraj primarily catches prawns and a few varieties of fish for a living, he is the go-to person for many birders and photographers visiting the lagoon town. “I regularly take photographers from Chennai, Coimbatore, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, and even Mumbai on my boat,” he says, rowing us along the Buckingham Canal, past a lone Asian openbill. He takes around four teams a week to see and photograph migrant birds, the chief attraction among them being greater flamingoes.

What draws them to the lagoon?

According to Chennai-based Nature photographer Munish Palaniappan, Pulicat is a photographer’s paradise. “The lighting across the vast expanse lends itself to dramatic photos,” says Munish, who also holds photography workshops. “Shooting birds here during the golden hour [minutes before sunrise and sunset] is an experience,” he says, adding that the historic port town’s proximity to Chennai is an added advantage.

Munish, who has mentored over 100 photographers over the



Right shade of pink

Thousand of flamingoes are at Pulicat lagoon, where fishermen-turned-guides ferry birders, enabling close sightings

years, brings them to Pulicat to show them the ropes. The still, endless waters from where one can observe birds from close quarters, is a good place to learn bird photography, he says. There are assured sightings of greater flamingoes through most of the year but Yuvaraj says that they fly away during the monsoon months since there is an increase in the water level. For several birders, visiting Pulicat is an annual ritual.

Bengaluru-based software engineer K Kishore Kumar has been going to Pulicat every year over the past five years. He usually visits during weekends with two other birding

friends, staying at a wedding hall in nearby Ponneri. “Yuvaraj takes us on his boat during sunset on Saturday when we get to photograph the birds with light falling on our back while we face the flamingoes,” he says, adding that they make another trip at sunrise the following day.

Yuvaraj, whose father and grandfather too went fishing in the waters of Pulicat, knows the names and behaviour of most winged visitors that stop by his hometown. “I picked this up from the birders,” he says. Most of them plan their stay at Ponneri or Gummidiipoondi. “A lot of good hotels have come up in the

Feast for the eyes Flamingoes in Pulicat; Yuvaraj (bottom right); during a boating trip. KISHORE KUMAR AND MUNISH PALANIAPPAN



nearby towns,” he points out.

Sri Vidhya and her husband VN Maheshwar from Coimbatore are regular visitors. “There are several wetlands in Coimbatore where we do birding, but I cannot explain in words the happiness I experience when I see a large flock of flamingoes,” she says, adding that this makes the long drive worth it.

“Flamingoes are the only birds that are in such a beautiful shade of pink,” says Chennai-based Karthik Ramamurthy, who takes Nature-lovers on guided birding trips across India and abroad. He takes several teams of birders and photographers to Pulicat every year. “I’ve brought people from Mumbai and Delhi, apart from Kochi,” he says. All of them come for the swathes of pink.

Where does the pink in the flamingo come from? “They are pink due to their diet,

which primarily consists of algae and tiny crustaceans rich in natural pigments called carotenoids,” according to NVK Ashraf, senior advisor with the Wildlife Trust of India. “Flamingoes are fascinating birds,” he adds: “They produce crop milk, a nutrient-rich substance that is bright red or pink in colour, to feed their chicks.” Munish says that the flamingoes that visit Pulicat fly down from the Rann of Kutch in Gujarat, a majority of them stopping at Mumbai. “They fly back to Gujarat for nesting,” he adds.

Government action While birding at Pulicat is largely unorganised, Munish feels some attention from the Tamil Nadu Government will help. “If such trips are regulated, it will benefit a lot of people,” he says.

The flamingoes, meanwhile, are blissfully unaware of all the attention they are getting. We see them when our boat comes to a stop after 30 minutes of chugging along shallow waters. Yuvaraj turns off the engine to push the boat close enough for us to admire a flock of some 250 birds without them feeling our presence. The wind carries their calls towards us: they sound like ducks, but more musical.

We are not here to photograph the birds, but to simply see their delicate pink feathers and long, graceful necks. After over 45 minutes, the flock moves away. Yuvaraj revs up the engine; it is time to head back to the shore and leave the pink behind.

Pulicat is about 60 kilometres from Chennai. The best time to see flamingoes is from 4pm to 6pm and 4am to 6am. Yuvaraj can be reached on 9710518040.



Take a bao

Get ready for a flavour-packed experience at Mr Ong – The Flavours of Singapore, where The Art of Bao, a limited-time culinary showcase, reimagines the humble bao (a traditional Chinese steamed bun) through inventive fillings and contemporary presentation. @Park Hyatt, Guindy. On till May 24. Reservations 8939871128.

Chennai’s Ignea moves beyond its Ibiza-style party phase with a new cocktail programme built around thoughtfully made drinks, fresh ingredients and a more grown-up night out



A swig of glitter (Clockwise from far left) Blue pea elixer; red pineapple wine highball; strawberry snowcap; and Turkish eggs. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



on extracting flavour from fresh ingredients, using technology and patience. The toddy-inspired, rum-based fermented bloom, stained a pretty pink with guava and dragon fruit, takes four days to make and carbonate. As a result flavours merge seamlessly.

Similarly, with the Legolasar Picante, made with tequila, jalapeno brine and fresh coriander, the pleasing burn of the jalapeno is deftly tempered by sweet agave.

I am not a fan of dessert cocktails, as I tend to find them a bit overwhelming. Hence I limit myself to a few sips of the Tiramisu Kaapi, Harish’s take on an espresso martini, using coconut for an audience that he says has been “brought up on filter coffee and Mysore pak”.

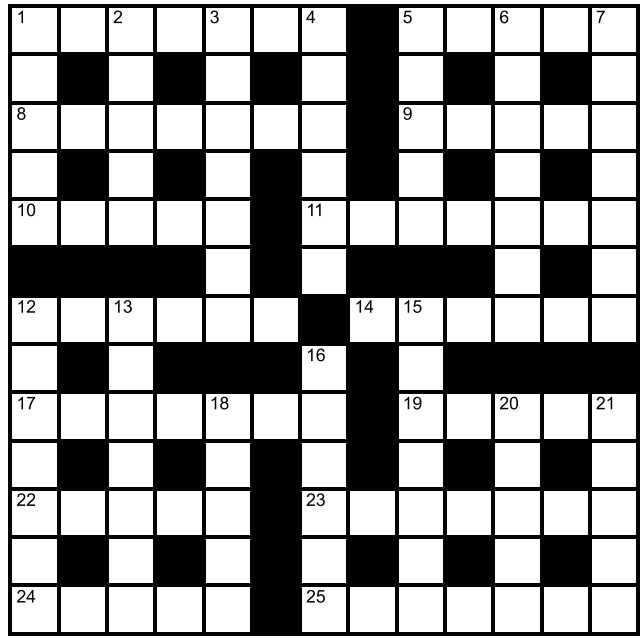
Not everyone will like every cocktail, though. And that is the whole point. The new range attempts to offer something for everyone. Even those of us who miss the sparkle of our party days: order Nebula No. 5, a cream-topped, fruit-forward drink with vodka, sage leaves, grapefruit, and edible golden glitter. Harish puts on his phone camera so we can admire the sparkle. “It represents the night,” he says, with a smile. “It’s like a trail of baby stars.”

The dance floor may be fading. But, sitting under the stars, sipping on glitter, feels like a fair trade.

Ignea Cocktail Bar & Rooftop Restaurant is at 58, Sterling Road, Nungambakkam. A meal for two including alcohol costs ₹3,999. For reservations, call 9047643786.



QUICK CROSSWORD #54 (Set by Doppelganger)

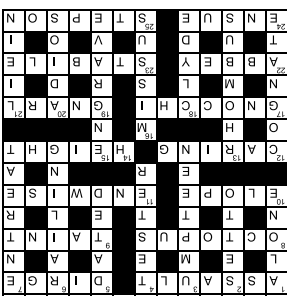


- Across**
- 1 Attack (7)
 - 5 Funeral hymn (5)
 - 8 A cephalopod mollusc (7)
 - 9 Disgrace (5)
 - 10 Run away with lover (5)
 - 11 Upright (7)
 - 12 Showing compassion (6)
 - 14 Distance from base to top (6)
 - 17 Dumplings (7)
 - 19 Protruding knot on tree (5)
 - 22 Monastery (5)
 - 23 Unchangeable (7)
 - 24 Follow (5)
 - 25 Spouse’s child from previous marriage (7)
- Down**
- 1 Solitary (5)
 - 2 Conflict (3-2)
 - 3 Countless (7)
 - 4 Examiner (6)
 - 5 Old-fashioned (5)
 - 6 Barrier (7)
 - 7 Beg (7)

To play The Guardian Quick Crossword, The Hindu Cryptic crossword, Sudoku & other puzzles online, scan the QR code.



- Solution No. 54**
- 12 Related by blood (7)
 - 13 Equilateral parallelogram (7)
 - 15 Carve (7)
 - 16 Mistress of a household (6)
 - 18 Scottish River (5)
 - 20 Goodbye (5)
 - 21 Repose (3-2)



The midnight sun

Shonali Muthalaly
shonali.m@thehindu.co.in

It looks like our clubbing days are done. Goodbye Cosmopolitans and sticky dance floors. This is the age of the serious Chennai cocktail bar.

Ignea by Midnight Sun, a Morocco-inspired bar set on Sterling Road, with a rooftop that makes you feel like you are on holiday, has shifted moods over the years to suit a changing audience. Launched in 2023, when the world was in the post-pandemic ‘YOLO’ phase, it aimed to be a Mediterranean escape but

quickly morphed into a party space. The last Saturday night I spent at Ignea years ago featured fire dancers, thumping music and flair bartending: a slice of Ibiza in Nungambakkam.

Now, it is quieter and more grown-up, with a strong focus on food and cocktails. Creative director and founder, Thirukumaran Roopkumar, has decided it is time for a shift, returning to their original relaxed Mediterranean escape avatar.

“I think the market is finally maturing. More people now appreciate cocktails that require a lot of work, and pay attention to what goes into

their drinks,” he says, adding, “We are going back to what we really wanted Ignea to be when we launched, but somewhere along the way we got diverted. This is going to be a space that focusses on conversation, memories and personalised service.”

As we talk, bartender Harish Veda starts shaking up and serving their new range of cocktails, starting with a tall, refreshing midnight basil spritz, which is crisp with botanical notes and gin.



Flip the bird (Left) Skateboarders at their 'spot' in Thiruvannmiyur; (below and inset) Jacob performing tricks. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Jacob. While students represent Tamil Nadu in competitions, they often veer away, following the long-winding pathway towards adult occupations, leaving behind the simple joys of floating on a wheeled-board. Jacob, who picked it easily because he had an edge as a dancer, chose to pursue the sport as a hobby. It has paid him back

handsomely. Today, he is a coach and also a competitor. He is skateboarding full-time after years of working at several retail spaces, and is happy about spearheading this cool culture in the city. It is why he has collaborated with Sphere Skateboards, a brand from Bengaluru that supplies skateboards, for a GOTY (Greatest Trick Of The Year) Jam on May 24 from 3pm. "Most people outside of Tamil Nadu do not know about the skateboarding culture here. When I visited Bengaluru in April, we set up a meeting with the Sphere guys who seemed keen on seeing what the scene here is like. We are anticipating around 30 skaters. I have asked other clubs to represent their styles too," he says. Jacob says that there will be two specific tricks on display. One is the ollie, a trick that one learns as a rookie. It is not as easy as it looks, says Jacob. The second is the game of skate: a trick-off involving some rock-paper-scissors and other shenanigans. Participants are sure to get free T-shirts and take a look at interesting looking merchandise, especially since style in this community is currency. "Today, Bengaluru is the skateboarding capital. Chennai does not have to get there but I am excited to meet new people who'd like to try new things. Honestly, it is among the chilltest ways to blow off some steam," he says.

GOTY (Greatest Trick Of The Year) Jam is on May 24 at the park below Thiruvannmiyur Railway Station, 3pm onwards. Entry is free. DM @chennai_sb_community on Instagram.

Master your ollie

Grab your things. We are going skateboarding in Thiruvannmiyur on Sunday

Sanjana Ganesh
sanjana.g@thehindu.co.in

Jacob Dan Paul may not have walked into a skating rink and learnt the ollie (a skating trick that involves flipping the skateboard) on his very first try back in 2016. But he is keen on creating an atmosphere for novices to try their hand at the sport. If you are good enough, you could even participate in their trick-off on May 24. Chennai Skateboarding Community began with the simple intention of being part of a crew, a community that is open to all levels of skateboarding prowess. "Many young people who skateboard tend to take on the pressure that a sense of competition imposes. Our group

that meets every Sunday hopes to be inclusive, practise, have fun, and indulge in a new hobby," says Jacob. On Sundays, every week at the park below the Thiruvannmiyur train station, around 20 skateboarders, usually between the ages 18 and 25, come by to try their hand. There is a good composition of women who also text him and ask if they could swing by. Members of the community watch tons of YouTube videos. The intention is to arrive with their boards on Sunday and try their luck at tricks and hone their skills. "About 90% of the people who board are Gen-Z college kids," he says. Skateboarding is still at a nascent stage in the city, says



Sweet talk

At Ritvah, ITC Grand Chola's new dessert boutique, laddos get a hazelnut truffle spin

S Poorvaia
poorvaja.sundar@thehindu.co.in

What if the humble besan ladoo came with a hazelnut twist? Or if pistachios and pumpkin seeds came together for a bite-sized barfi?

At Ritvah, ITC Grand Chola's new premium mithai boutique, the appeal of the Indian mithai, in all of its shapes, sizes, flavours and textures comes elevated with modern flavours and aesthetics. "While the idea was born from us wanting to come up with contemporary desserts or mithai, we were keen on retaining the essence of our traditional Indian sweets," says Nikhil Nagpal, executive chef. The sweets at Ritvah are categorised under different collections such as Classics Reimagined which include boondi kalakand rolls, malai khaja flake, and badushah, The Nut Reserve which has the pista paan delicacy, almond pistachio praline sandwich, and kaju cranberry sheer, and The Contemporary Indian Patisserie which has creations like the rabri taco and gulab jamun cheese indulgence. For Nikhil, inspiration for the many sweets Ritvah has to offer was all around him. "We noticed that baked gulab jamun, or gulab jamun rabdi, was popular in our banquets and came up with a gulab jamun cheese indulgence; a gulab jamun centered inside some cream cheese and mascarpone on a base of sable, topped with saffron strands." With an emphasis on responsible luxury, experiments with forgotten grains and indigenous experiments



also feature on the menu, with The Heritage Grains and Ladoo Edit featuring almond jowar laddos, paanch beej laddos, and the besan hazelnut truffle ladoo. From a box of delicately crafted mithai, we pick a kaju cranberry sheer to sample first. The rosette-shaped mithai tastes like a rich kaju katli, the sweetness balanced out by a mild hint of tart cranberry. While the besan hazelnut truffle ladoo feels like a decadent, bite-sized explosion of flavours, the gulabhand in the almond gulabhand essence overpowers the senses and the mithai is a bit too sweet. Ritvah has sugar-free as well as nut-free offerings. And for that much needed savoury relief, pick local favourites like the Madras mixture, moongphali masala moori, peri peri cashewnuts, togarashi almonds, and a zingy kalimirsch nimki. With everyone making a beeline for Indian mithai to gift during the festive season, Nikhil also explains that they had to work extensively on the packaging and presentation. "Taste takes precedence of course, and once that fell into place, we sat down to work out how the sweets would look like in a box, plan colours, textures and combinations accordingly as well," he says. While Ritvah's offerings are currently available through takeaway at their boutique, the sweets and savouries will soon expand to home delivery formats as well.



Mithai magic (Top) Sweets on the menu at Ritvah; and (above) the boutique. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Ritvah is located at the lobby level, ITC Grand Chola, Guindy. Mithai boxes from ₹704 onwards

A third space (Clockwise from below) Ice cream with caramel; Grounded cafe entrance; muffins. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Diya Vakada

It is a wonderful time for coffee lovers in Chennai. Every other month it would appear that a new cafe is opening, and like a moth to a flame, beverage enthusiasts unearth these cafes, finding new ways to consume the drinks they know and love. Grounded by the Hawk Federation is Anna Nagar's newest contribution to the coffee space, built to accommodate anything one might want to do while sipping their beverage of choice. The Hawk Federation is a Chennai-based clothing company, founded by Kevin Moses, who branched out from clothing to start a cafe. "I wanted to make a community that is based around coffee culture similar to that of Mumbai and Bengaluru," says Kevin when asked what made him take up this passion project. The hope is for the cafe to be seen as a space that can be a second office or a second home, he says. Grounded certainly has the space to be both of those things. It covers an area of about 7,500 square feet, a



Sip on this

Grounded, open till 2am, in Anna Nagar offers a home theatre, work spaces and coffee

large area for a cafe. Here, work meetings can be taken in a conference room (available to rent at ₹1,500 per hour); a home theatre is available to rent out for ₹1,000 per hour; and a fully equipped gaming room becomes the perfect place to unwind. Customers can do anything they want, from watching their favourite movies to sitting alone and ruminating over their caffeine addictions. Grounded hopes to draw in the Gen-Z crowd. It remains open from 8am to 2am the next day, the timings set to keep up with Anna Nagar's renowned nightlife.

Grounded debuts with an ambitious beverage menu, blending items that aren't commonly paired together. They have a range of speciality coffees, including an adventurous blueberry iced coffee, which might be more of an acquired taste. The tiramisu



latte and the crème brûlée transform your favourite desserts into drinks. A fresh strawberry espresso spritz or a coffee honey lemonade is also available if one wants to opt for something less decadent. There was certainly no shortage of creativity when it came to curating the selection of drinks. The cafe opened in February this year and, as of this month, has introduced a daily special menu with a limited number of food items. A highlight from this trial menu is the pesto sandwich, which is served with fresh pesto and soft bread, and it is stuffed with either prawn or paneer, depending on your preference. There is a range of desserts and pastas available, including caramel chocolate muffins and a Biscoff and raspberry blondie. The space has potential to be the frequent third space for coffee lovers that it clearly hopes to become. Yet the cafe still shows clear signs that it is in its nascent stages and is figuring out its rhythm. What exactly the focal point of the cafe is becomes convoluted. The hesitancy in introducing a full menu might be taken as a sign that Grounded hopes to perfect what they already have before adding more. As of now, it establishes itself as a cafe with the potential to bring something new into a coffee lover's world.

Grounded cafe is at 1st Street, Block M, Block F, Ammanagar East. For reservations, call 8937469409. A meal for two costs ₹1,500.

ARCHITECTURE, BUILD & INTERIOR DESIGN EXPO

SPECTA
QUARTZ SURFACES
PRESENTS

ACE
REFLECT

POWERED BY
HAVELLS

2 DAYS TO GO
FREE ENTRY

23•24 MAY 2026
TIME: 10:00 AM - 7:00 PM
CHENNAI TRADE CENTRE

VISITORS BELOW 16 YEARS ARE NOT PERMITTED

SCAN QR TO REGISTER

—SUPPORTED BY—

VISITORS BELOW 16 YEARS ARE NOT PERMITTED

BUSINESS EVENT
FORMAL ATTIRE MANDATORY

ace
interior
design

ABEC
ACCREDITED

www.acerect.com

CM YK 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32 33 34 35 36 37 38 39 40 41 42 43 44 45 46 47 48 49 50 51 52 53 54 55 56 57 58 59 60 61 62 63 64 65 66 67 68 69 70 71 72 73 74 75 76 77 78 79 80 81 82 83 84 85 86 87 88 89 90 91 92 93 94 95 96 97 98 99 100 A

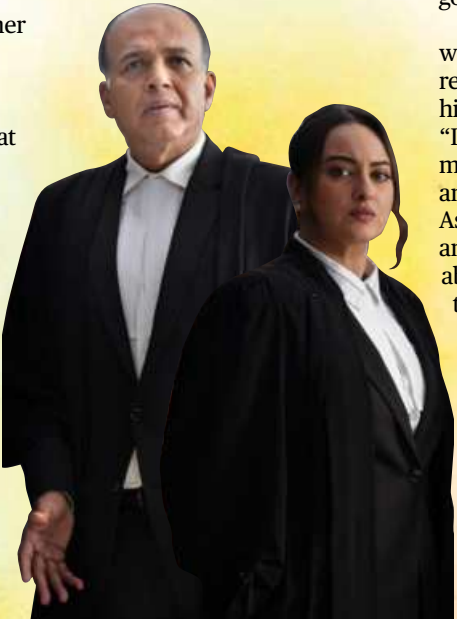


All about upcoming courtroom drama *System*, starring Jyotika, Sonakshi Sinha and Ashutosh Gowariker

The case is open

Shreyas Pande
shreyas.pande@thehindu.co.in

Jyotika’s eyes summon fear in *Chandramukhi*, conceal heartbreak in *Kaathal*: The *Core*, and bring mystery in Ashwiny Iyer Tiwari’s courtroom drama *System*. Nearly 26 years after her Hindi debut, the actor finds herself in the middle of an unexpected second innings in Bollywood – one, she says, that happened entirely by chance. “There was no conscious thought of coming to Hindi films. I came here for my kids and parents. After that, I started getting offers for work. It happened organically. I did a lot of films in the South and because of that ground work, I am getting work in Hindi films now,” says Jyotika. Discussing work in the Hindi OTT space, she says “The call-sheets are different in the South as you start work



early and by 6pm you are free. But in Hindi, the shifts are from 9am to 9pm, which make you feel that you spent the entire day on set.” She adds, “I think this is the most exciting time of my career. I am getting to do roles here which I don’t think I

would have got after 40 otherwise.”

The challenge was the same even for actor-filmmaker Ashutosh Gowariker, as he worked on playing a lawyer in *System*, something, “which he had never played before”. As an actor, Ashutosh worked in a bunch of films and television shows in the 1990s before completely pursuing direction with films like *Lagaan*, *Swades*, *Jodha Akbar* and more. In 2016 he returned on-screen with the Marathi film, *Ventilator*. “As a director, when I am explaining to actors what I expect in a particular shot, it also ends up honing my craft. But I am petrified as an actor whenever I go on set now,” he says.

In order to get comfortable with the material, Ashutosh requests directors to sit with him for a reading of his scenes. “I want to go through the material without any inhibition and let the director correct me. Ashwiny gave me that time and answered all my questions about the character. Only after that, did I felt alright to do a common reading with other actors,” he says.

He brings the antagonistic force in *System*, creating hurdles for his daughter, Neha, working as a public prosecutor to prove her worth. Sonakshi Sinha brings restraint to Neha, internalising her concerns even in the courtroom

Profit and laws Jyotika in *System*; (below) Sonakshi Sinha and Ashutosh Gowariker. PRIME VIDEO

scenes, which have traditionally invoked a lot of drama in Hindi films.

“The only impression of a lawyer I had was through the films I had seen. But Ashwiny told me to watch actual courtroom proceedings from YouTube, where I saw a lot of female lawyers arguing a case, interacting with witnesses and speaking to the judge. All of that actually relaxed me a bit for how real and normal it felt. There was no over-the-top screaming and shouting,” Sonakshi says.

Ashwiny’s voice lends a sensitive gaze to the film, which doesn’t resort to sensationalism to make its point but works around with an understated realism to comment on the idea of justice. Sonakshi feels that the approach of a female director stands out. “It is refreshing to work with a female director when you are used to working with male directors often. Ashwiny brought a certain vulnerability to the film which comes from being a woman,” she says.

Jyotika was impressed with the way Ashwiny treated the male characters in the film. “She made the men in the film look quite vulnerable. We rarely see that. We are so lost in defining a man to be powerful, trapped by responsibilities and never to be seen crying on-screen. She did the opposite by showing the vulnerable side of men and inner strength of the women characters.”

“When I think of Ashwiny, I think of all the giggles on the set. She made the atmosphere quite light-hearted. She was receptive of anything we said. We could tell her just about anything, call her multiple times during the day just to talk to her about the dress I was wearing. That woman-to-woman bond made it a little easier,” Jyotika says.

System will release on Prime Video on May 22.

When it rains

‘Katchi Sera’ star Samyuktha Viswanathan talks about her upcoming film *Double Occupancy*

Bhuvanesh Chandar
bhuvanesh.chandar@thehindu.co.in

Actor Samyuktha Viswanathan has been busy, particularly since her breakout appearance in composer Sai Abhyankkar’s indie hit ‘Katchi Sera’ in 2024. When we catch her, the actor, who is juggling many projects, like *I Am Game* and *Mr Bhaarah*, is gearing up for a dubbing session for her upcoming release, *Double Occupancy*. “They say, ‘when it rains, it pours.’ The last few weeks have been a lot of overworking, doing multiple things at once. I’m excited, but I am also trying to give my best to each of the things that I need to do,” says Samyuktha.

Samyuktha made her acting debut in the 2021 romance drama *Oh Manapenne* and subsequently starred in a few web series. However, it was ‘Katchi Sera’ that catapulted her to fame.

Unlike before, people now need not necessarily be in a movie or series to get famous; even a music video can do that. It indeed does seem like many spaces have opened to young women, at least much more than what the previous generation of female actors were exposed to. But are we picking out exceptions, or has there been a genuine shift? “I definitely think there are a lot more entry points because only a type of woman could enter the industry once; they had to look a certain way, have a certain skin colour and so on. That has changed.” She cites the example of her Prime Video series, *Suzhal: The Vortex*

Season 2, which featured a diverse set of young women. But she agrees that the change has been slow. “If you look, in general, at the heroines and the heroines of our industry, there’s a pattern to how the heroines look.”

In *Double Occupancy*, directed by Aswin Kandasamy, Samyuktha plays Priya. The actor says there hasn’t been a female character written as layered

as Priya is. “It’s easy for females to be put in a box or a type, like ‘bubbly’ or ‘serious’ or ‘shy’ and so on. In reality, however, women are more nuanced and layered. What you see on the outside is not always the person on the inside. And I think this character made me feel that. She felt like a real person who would exist in this world.” From the title promo, *Double Occupancy* seems to be a fantasy drama that follows a character, Rajini, who switches their gender depending on the time of day. “It’s like a genre bender; there’s fantasy, there’s romance, comedy, drama, and action. But at the end of the day, the story is about human emotions.”

Up next, Samyuktha will be seen with Malayalam star Dulquer Salmaan in *I Am Game*. She also has *Mr Bhaarah*, produced by Lokesh Kanagaraj, *Texas Tiger*, co-starring Hridhu Haroon, and *Romcom*, produced by Annapurna Studios and Chai Bisket Films. “And besides that, I also did an experimental film that I have been travelling with for over four years,” she signs off.

Social media following should not affect an actor’s relevancy. A film without someone with millions of followers can still bring audiences to theatres

SAMYUKTHA VISWANATHAN



Striking balance
Samyuktha Viswanathan. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

All in the family

How actor-producer Saiju Kurup views the success of *Bharathanatyam 2: Mohiniyattam*

Athira M
athira.m@thehindu.co.in

Saiju Kurup is ecstatic. His *Bharathanatyam 2: Mohiniyattam*, which he acted in and co-produced, is trending on Netflix after raking in crores at the box office. “I ask myself if this is all for real. I have been waiting for this – a theatre hit – since my debut, which means the last 21 years,” says Saiju.

The success is special since the film’s prequel, *Bharathanatyam*, released in 2024, did not do well in theatres but was loved on OTT [Prime Video]. “We collected just under ₹30 lakh in all for *Bharathanatyam*. Now we are talking in crores, and that is crazy!”

Both films, directed by Krishnadas Murali, revolve around Sasindran Nair (Saiju) and his predicament, thanks to his family comprising his parents, siblings and co-brothers. While in *Bharathanatyam*, he had to deal with the brouhaha that erupts when his father reveals he has another wife and son, in *Mohiniyattam*, he pulls out all stops to cover up an accidental homicide committed by his family.

The success of *Mohiniyattam* is everything that he could have asked for as an actor, says Saiju. “I had new targets at every stage of my career when my debut film [*Mayookham*] as a



protagonist didn’t work. After that, my first goal was to work in a film that ran for 100 days at the box office, irrespective of my screen time. *Hallo* and *Chocolate* (both released in 2007) did that for me. As time went by, I wanted the audience to trust me as an actor.”

However, the films in which he played the lead never emerged as hits in theatres. “They either had an okay run at the box office or did well on OTT platforms,” he says, “I was in a happy space but was waiting for the so-called theatre hit until *Mohiniyattam*.”

It was a confident Saiju that everyone saw at the pre-release interviews of *Mohiniyattam*. “What happened post-release was unbelievable. It reminded me of what Paulo Coelho wrote, ‘When you want something, all the universe conspires in helping you achieve it.’”

Saiju admits that there was a time when he decided to stick to supporting roles after his films as the protagonist did not do well.

Has that changed now? “I am more confident now. I believe if the content is good, people will come to theatres,” says Saiju, who will soon be seen playing the lead in films such as *Aaram* and *The Third Murder* and is also part of *Premapitta*, *Lurk* and *Bafana United*.

Mohiniyattam is currently streaming on Netflix.

CREAMCentre
VEGETARIAN LEGACY SINCE 1998
Veg Fine Dining Restaurant

ALPHONSO MANGO SPECIAL

Indulge in the richness of seasonal mango specials.
A perfect blend of flavour and summer joy.

For Banquets & Outdoor Catering ☎ 98843 96651 / 98843 59759

BA Puram 044 4281 5777	Nungambakkam 044 4356 1777	Anna nagar 044 4353 7077	Adyar 044 4630 4777
---------------------------	-------------------------------	-----------------------------	------------------------

— The —
PALOMAR
BY CROSSWAY

Z&L
GARDEN
EVENT VENUE

Celebrating
life’s finest moments with unmatched
hospitality & style

FOR BOOKINGS, CALL: +91 8925848868
THE PALOMAR BY CROSSWAY | 4A2, East Coast Rd,
Akkarai, Sholinganallur, Chennai, Tamil Nadu 600119

thepalomarbycrossway